



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large orange circle with a slight drop shadow, containing the text "does free will explain all evil?" in white, lowercase, sans-serif font.

does free
will explain
all evil?

1. The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami is an evil.
 2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.
 3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
 4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1,2,3)
 5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.
-

C. God does not exist. (4,5)

The argument from natural evil

A second reply focuses on the fact that there were evils before human beings existed. Here's one prominent version of this reply, from William Rowe:

“Traditional free-will approaches - with their move to shift responsibility and/or blame for evil away from God and onto personal creatures - are stalemated by horrendous evil. Human radical vulnerability to horrors cannot have its origin in misused created freedom, because - even if one accepted the story of Adam’s fall as historical (which I do not) - the way it is told, humans were radically vulnerable to horrors from the beginning, even in Eden. The framework within which the primal ancestors made their choices was such that obedient choices meant persistence of the status quo, while disobedient choices would result in the horrendous disarray such as humans have experienced ever since. Even if Adam’s and Eve’s choices are supposed to be somehow self-determined, the fact that the consequences amplify far beyond their capacity to conceive and hence to intend - viz., to horrors of which ex hypothesi they had no prior experience and of which they could therefore have no adequate conception - is not something for which humans are responsible. Rather it is a function of the interaction between human agency and the wider framework within which it is set, and God is responsible for creating human beings in such a framework!”

“Suppose that in some distant forest lightning strikes a dead tree, resulting in a forest fire. In the fire a fawn is trapped, horribly burned, and lies in terrible agony for several days before death relieves its suffering. ... So far as we can see, the fawn's intense suffering is pointless. For there does not appear to be any greater good such that the prevention of the fawn's suffering would require either the loss of that good or the occurrence of an evil equally bad or worse.”

Surely many events such as these occurred before human beings were on the scene; and surely at least some animal suffering of this kind is an evil.



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2 There is no good without weight and which is

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God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good



the ability
to harm others
is a great good

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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